

THIRD HAND PLAY

ABOUT THE DEALS

South will always be declarer and you will be in the East position.

Partner has made the opening lead, declarer has played from dummy and it will be your turn to play.

Feel free to disagree with the bidding which is more or less Standard American, not 2-Over-1.

You are asked to study the information available and decide what you would play.

THIRD HAND LESSON

If your only ambition is to be a better-than-average defender then you don't have to read this entire lesson.

Instead, just learn this one simple rule and you will be about 75% of good.

When partner's opening lead is a low card and dummy holds no high cards in the suit you should always play your highest card.

That's it. It's called Third Hand High and Bridge teachers have been stressing it for many years. The idea is that you don't want declarer to win the first trick with a small card. If your high card wins the trick, fine, but if not you want to force Declarer to use a high card to get the trick.

Here are a couple of examples.

♠ 8 5 3
♠ K J 7 4 2  ♠ A 6
♠ Q 10 9

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♠4.

If you correctly play your ♠A and then return your ♠6 your side will take the first 5 ♠ tricks.

If you do not play the ♠A on this trick declarer will win an undeserved trick, perhaps the extra one he needs to make the contract.

♥ 7 5
♥ Q 10 8 3  ♥ K 9 4 2
♥ A J 6

Defending against a ♠ contract your partner, West, leads the ♥3.

You are certain that South holds the ♥A because partner would not underlead an Ace as the opening lead against a suit contract.

However, the lead of a low card does indicate an honor in the suit, so to protect that honor you must put your ♥K on the trick.

If you get cheap and decide to save your ♥K for later South will win the first trick with the ♥J and in fact won't lose a ♥ trick at all.

There you have it. Play Third-hand-high and you will be a pretty darn good defender.
But if you want to be an excellent defender, (and for times when you do not play Third-hand-high), read on.

What to play when you have touching high cards:

There is a very good common sense rule that is used most of the time in Bridge.

When leading one of equal honors, start with the highest one.
When playing third hand one of equal honors, play the lowest one.

♦ 8 3 2		
♦ K 10 7 5		♦ Q J 4
♦ A 9 6		

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♦5.

You want to play third-hand-high, but that doesn't mean you should put on the ♦Q.

Since you also have the ♦J, that is the card you should play.

It may seem that it wouldn't matter, and of course it doesn't matter **TO YOU**.

But put yourself on partner's side of the table. If you play the ♦Q and South wins with the ♦A, West cannot tell where the ♦J is, and will assume that South holds it.

But if you correctly play the ♦J and South wins with the ♦A partner will know for sure that you also hold the ♦Q, since if South held that card he would not have used his ♦A to win the trick.

Here is an obvious extension of that last example.

♦ J 3 2		
♦ K 8 7 5		♦ Q 10 4
♦ A 9 6		

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♦5.

Dummy plays low and you want to play third-hand-high, but that doesn't mean you should put on the ♦Q. Since dummy has the ♦J, your ♦Q and ♦10 are equals so you play the ♦10.

What if dummy has a high card:

When dummy comes down with a high card that you can beat it is often better to keep your winner to quash the high card in dummy.

♣ Q 7 5
 ♣ K 9 8 3 ♣ A J 2
 ♣ 10 6 4

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♣3.

Declarer plays the ♣5 from dummy.

In this example you can see that playing third-hand-high would be a mistake.

Partner's low ♣ lead indicates he holds an honor, which might be the King.

If you play your ♣A on this trick partner's ♣K will also win a trick but the third trick in the suit will be taken by dummy's ♣Q.

Instead play your ♣J and your side can take the first four tricks.

In case you're worried that South might hold the ♣K then quit worrying. If he does hold the ♣K and you put your ♣A on the trick then you will have established TWO ♣ winners for him. Play the ♣J and keep your ♣A to stop dummy's ♣Q from being a winner.

♠ J 5 3
 ♠ Q 10 7 2 ♠ K 9 6
 ♠ A 8 7

Defending against a Suit contract your partner, West, leads the ♠2.

(Remember, partner would NOT underlead an Ace as the opening lead in a suit contract.)

You should play the ♠9 because if you play your ♠K South will win the ♠A and later make a second trick in the suit by leading toward the ♠J.

If this is a Notrump contract the situation is more difficult because against Notrump partner might have led from ♠A Q 7 2. So against Notrump you use your best judgement (based on the bidding) as to which is more likely for West; ♠A Q 7 2 or ♠Q 10 7 2.

The Rule of Eleven

When partner makes an opening lead that is fourth-highest, subtract the value of that card from eleven. The result will be the number of cards in dummy, your hand, and declarer's hand that are higher than the card led.

If you want to know more about this rule there is a full lesson on BakerBridge. Meanwhile, here are a couple of examples:

♥ K 7 2

♥ Q 10 8 6 ♥ A J 9 2

♥ 5 4

West leads the ♥6, which you take to be fourth-highest.

The ♥2 is played from dummy.

Subtract 11 - 6 and the answer is 5, the number of cards in North, East and South that are higher than the ♥6. Since you can see all five of those cards in your hand and dummy, you play low and West's ♥6 will hold the trick.

Notice that declarer would have been better off to cover the ♥6 with dummy's ♥7.

♦ Q 9 4

♦ 10 8 7 5 ♦ A J 6

♦ K 3 2

Defending against a Notrump contract after South has shown opening hand strength, your partner, West, leads the ♦5 and the ♦4 is played from dummy.

You apply the Rule of Eleven; $11 - 5 = 6$.

Since you can see 5 of the ♦s that are above the 5, you know that South has just one card that can beat the ♦5. It is very likely that this card is the ♦K, and while you cannot prevent it from winning a trick you can force South to play it just by playing the ♦6.

If you incorrectly play the ♦J South will win with the ♦K and then score a second ♦ trick by finessing the ♦9 later.

When partner leads an honor card:

Partner will lead the top card of an honor sequence so you should be able to figure out his holding. Your first concern here is probably whether to signal for him to continue the suit or not.

Another concern, though, is whether you have a high honor yourself that may cause the suit to be blocked.

♣ 8 5 3

♣ Q J 10 7 4 ♣ K 2

♣ A 9 6

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♣Q.

Declarer plays the ♣3 from dummy.

If you decide to play low, (since partner's ♣Q is equal to your ♣K), South will most likely hold up his ♣A.

When West continues the suit and your ♣K is played, South will hold up again. Since you are now out of ♣s you will be unable to continue to attack in what is probably your side's best suit.

Instead, you should play your ♣K. Now if South holds up you can continue the suit and if South continues to hold up West will be able to establish the rest of his ♣s.

Here is an extension of that principle.

	♣ A 5 3	
♣ Q J 10 7 4		♣ K 2
	♣ 9 8 6	

Defending against a Notrump contract your partner, West, leads the ♣Q.
 Declarer plays the ♣A from dummy.
 If you decide to hoard your ♣K and play low, then when your side gains the lead again the ♣ suit will be blocked by your King.
 You should unblock by playing the ♣K underneath dummy's ♣A. Now, whenever your side gets the lead the attack on the ♣ suit can be continued.

It may happen that partner leads an honor card and you have a higher honor in the suit. Generally you would not want to waste two high-cards on the same trick, but there may be a pressing reason for you to do so.

	♠ J	
	♥ 8 2	
♠ K Q 9 8 2		♠ A 10 6 4
♥ 10 9 6 5		♥ K Q 7 4
	♠ 7 5 3	
	♥ A J 3	

Defending against 6♣, your partner, West, leads the ♠K.
 North's singleton means your side will only get 1 ♠ trick, so your ♠A is essentially wasted.
 You want to try to establish a ♥ winner, and the easiest way to make sure ♥s are led next is to do it yourself.
 So overtake partner's ♠K with your ♠A and play the ♥K.

There is a lot more that could be said about Third Hand play, but . . .
 . . . 20 Practice Deals should be better than another 2000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠2

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣4

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠3

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠7

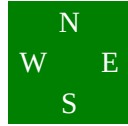
Board: 6
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥8

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 9 4
♥ J 9 8 5
♦ Q J 10 5
♣ J 10

♠ A J
♥ K Q 4 3
♦ A 7 3
♣ K 6 5 2



♠ 8 6 5 3
♥ A 7 2
♦ K 6 4
♣ A 8 7

♠ K 10 7 2
♥ 10 6
♦ 9 8 2
♣ Q 9 4 3

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♠ 2			

The bidding has been as shown. Partner led the ♠ 2, dummy played the ♠ 3

Play the ♠ Q. This is a perfect example of why you should USUALLY play Third-hand-high.

If you do not put your ♠ Q on this trick declarer will get an undeserved winner with his ♠ J. In this Deal it will be his ninth trick. Play Third-hand-high and he will go down, otherwise he will make his contract.

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K 10 7 4

♥ 10 4

♦ 9 5 3

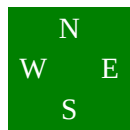
♣ A Q J 3

♠ 2

♥ A 8 7 6 2

♦ K 8 4

♣ 10 8 5 2



♠ A Q J 8 6 3

♥ K 3

♦ Q 10 7

♣ K 6

♠ 9 5

♥ Q J 9 5

♦ A J 6 2

♣ 9 7 4

West

North

East

South

3 ♠

Pass

4 ♠

Pass

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

Lead: ♥ Q

The bidding has been as shown. Partner led the ♥ Q, dummy played the ♥ 4

Play the ♥ A. You dare not play low for fear declarer might win a singleton ♥ K.

And when you win the first trick, (the ♥ K does NOT fall), you have to decide what to do next. Do not just return the suit like a robot since it is obvious that you have no more ♥ winners and you surely won't win any ♣ tricks.

You need to switch to a ♦, and the ♦ 4, (low from an honor) is recommended.

Played this way you will defeat the contract by one trick. If you allow declarer to win the first trick he will pull trumps and discard two red losers on dummy's ♣ and make an overtrick.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 5 3
 ♥ Q 10 6
 ♦ K 6 2
 ♣ A 10 6 4

♠ K 9 8
 ♥ A 8 5
 ♦ Q J 9 4
 ♣ 9 7 3



♠ Q 7 4 2
 ♥ 9 7 4 3
 ♦ 8 7
 ♣ Q J 2

♠ A 10 6
 ♥ K J 2
 ♦ A 10 5 3
 ♣ K 8 5

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♣4			

The bidding has been as shown. Partner led the ♣4, dummy played the ♣3

Third-hand-high is usually a good plan to follow, certainly that is true in this deal. But that doesn't mean you should blindly play your HIGHEST card, rather you should play the LOWEST of high-equals.

In other words, in this case you should play the ♣J, which is equal to the ♣Q.

If instead you play the ♣Q, figuring it makes no difference, you'd be right that it makes no difference to you. But partner would then assume that it is declarer with the ♣J, and when he obtains the lead with the ♦K he will be unlikely to lead another ♣, which would be too bad for your side.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 9 5

♥ A K J 9 7 2

♦ 8

♣ 9 7 3

♠ Q 8 7 3

♥ 10 5

♦ A 5 4 2

♣ 8 4 2



♠ J 6 4

♥ Q 8

♦ K 9 7 3

♣ K Q J 10

♠ K 10 2

♥ 6 4 3

♦ Q J 10 6

♣ A 6 5

West

1 ♥

2 ♥

All Pass

4 ♥ by West

Lead: ♠ 3

North

Pass

Pass

East

2 ♣

4 ♥

South

Pass

The bidding has been as shown. Partner led the ♠ 3, dummy played the ♠ 4

Play the ♠ 10.

Partner's low ♠ lead tells you that he has an honor in the suit. There are only two ♠ honors you can't see, and you know he wouldn't underlead an Ace at a suit contract. So partner holds the ♠ Q.

You can see clearly what would happen if you played Third-hand-high and put on your ♠ K. Declarer would win his ♠ A and could then set up a second ♠ trick by leading toward dummy's ♠ J.

By playing the ♠ 10 you force declarer to win with the ♠ A if he wants the trick. But however he plays he can only make one ♠ trick when you play correctly.

For your side, 2 ♠ tricks and the two minor Aces spell defeat.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

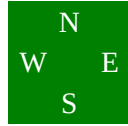
♠ A J 9 2
♥ 10 7 5 3
♦ A 4 2
♣ 9 7

♠ 6 4

♥ K Q 2

♦ K J 10 3

♣ A K 8 3



♠ Q 10 8 7

♥ 9 6 4

♦ 8 7 5

♣ 10 6 4

♠ K 5 3

♥ A J 8

♦ Q 9 6

♣ Q J 5 2

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♠ 7

The bidding has been as shown. Partner led the ♠ 7, dummy played the ♠ 3

Play the ♠ 2.

Partner has led a small card, so it is surely fourth-down. That means you should automatically apply the Rule of Eleven.

11 minus 7 equals 4, so there are just 4 cards higher than the 7 between dummy, you, and declarer. **AND YOU CAN SEE ALL FOUR OF THEM.**

Declarer has no card that can beat the ♠ 7, and the only way you can beat this contract is to let partner's ♠ 7 hold the trick. He will continue the suit, allowing you to pick up dummy's ♠ K and four ♠ winners. Along with the ♦ A you will defeat the contract.

If you play ANY card except your ♠ 2 on the first trick you will not be able to win four tricks in the suit because you cannot get East back into the lead. And declarer will make the contract easily.

Board 6

North Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K 10 7 5

♥ 6

♦ K 8 3

♣ Q J 9 5 2

♠ 6 4

♥ K 10 9 7 4 3

♦ A Q 7

♣ A 10



♠ A Q J 8 2

♥ A Q J 5

♦ J 6

♣ 7 4

♠ 9 3

♥ 8 2

♦ 10 9 5 4 2

♣ K 8 6 3

*West**North**East**South*

2♥

1♥

1♠

Pass

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by East

Lead: ♥8

The bidding has been as shown. West's 2♥ bid shows good ♠ support with at least 10 points.

Partner led the ♥8, dummy played the ♥6

Play a small ♥.

Partner's ♥8 lead is a high spot card, either top-of-nothing, or a singleton or doubleton. He definitely does not have an honor, which means that East holds ♥ A Q J.

In other words, your ♥K is dead in the water. BUT, if you play it to this trick you hand East three ♥ tricks, while if you play a low ♥ he can only get 2 winners in the suit.

The extra winner would permit East to discard 2 of dummy's ♦ losers, and this would give East the contract.